

York and comes back. There is a time lag... But people are looking for instant- or near-instant settlement, which can be possible through an RTGS kind of system. We want to set up a similar system here, but not necessarily run by us. We will probably let a market participant or a consortium run this facility... On the payments system, the consultations are over and the regulations will release sometime in January.



There is a view that GIFT City has not taken off like a Dubai or Singapore IFSC. What's your view?

A lot of residential buildings [and] infrastructure development are under planning or under construction. The GIFT City authority is developing the social infrastructure. The metro link will be inaugurated [soon], which will provide direct connectivity to the airport and the city (Ahmedabad). The Mumbai-Ahmedabad high-speed railway line is likely to come up by 2027... GIFT City has the ability to become an international financial destination.



How long will this take?

You will see this taking shape in about five years. We already have about 25,000-26,000 people working here. Many offices such as that of IBM and Google are coming up. Maybe [in the] next five years we'll have at least about 60,000 people working out of this place. Simultaneously, the state government and other entities, including IFSCA, are working on deepening the talent pool... We have brought out a universities framework... We are also actively working with sectoral regulators. **BT**

@surabhi_prasad

tion to operate from India and tap the massive market," says Riaz Thingna, Partner at consultancy Grant Thornton Bharat.

Currently, many India-centric businesses operate from jurisdictions like Mauritius, the UAE and Singapore to avail of tax-friendly policies. With GIFT City, these businesses will find it more beneficial to work within the same time zone and yet benefit from the tax breaks offered, which are comparable to these jurisdictions, he says.

The government and IFSCA have helped create a very business-friendly environment consistent with the focus on ease of doing business. "This has already started attracting family offices, banks, reinsurance, investment funds like

alternate investment funds, gold exchanges, and the like. International companies are also setting up Centres of Excellence in GIFT City and the trend is growing," adds Thingna.

According to M.S. Sahoo, Distinguished Professor at National Law University Delhi and founder Chairperson of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (IBBI), a market typically develops when it has regulatory comfort—and that comfort came with the setting up of the IFSCA. But GIFT City is a work in progress and will take time to fully bloom, he adds. "A lot of construction and infrastructure development is underway. Social infrastructure such as a relaxation zone

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HASMUKH ADHIA
CHAIRMAN, GIFT CITY



TAPAN RAY
MD & GROUP CEO, GIFT CITY

Veteran bureaucrats Hasmukh Adhia and Tapan Ray, the Chairman and MD & Group CEO, respectively, believe GIFT City is the first choice for investors because of the financial regulations implemented there